Personal Narratives

H 1928

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A. Background

The subdivision ***--Personal narratives*** is a free-floating form subdivision used under names of events and wars for collective or individual eyewitness reports and/or autobiographical accounts of these events and wars. Prior to 1977, the subdivision was used more widely under classes of persons, types of activities, and diseases. Those uses were replaced by the subdivision ***--Biography*** under classes of persons.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Diaries***. For guidelines on bio-bibliography, see H 1328. For guidelines on assigning headings to personal correspondence, see H 1480. For guidelines on biography, see H 1330. For guidelines on diaries, see H 1538. For guidelines on interviews, see H 1678. For guidelines on genealogy and family histories, see H 1631.

B. Recent revisions

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. Definitions

Personal narratives: collective or individual eyewitness reports and/or autobiographical accounts of wars or disasters.

D. General rule

Use the subdivision ***--Personal narratives*** under names of individual events or wars.

If the work being cataloged covers a particular event such as a battle which is part of a larger conflict, assign the heading for the specific event subdivided by ***--Personal narratives***.

LC practice: Assign the subject headings for the war or event. Do not assign the form subdivision ***--Personal narratives***. Assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Personal narratives*** and/or a more specific term, e.g. ***Diaries***.

E. National or ethnic qualifier

When used under names of wars, battles, etc., qualify the subdivision ***--Personal narratives*** by a national or ethnic qualifier to bring out the nationality or ethnic background of the narrator(s) of the account(s), for example, ***World War, 1939 1945--Personal narratives, American***. Omit the national or ethnic qualifier if it would cause redundancy within the heading.

Under names of events not associated with a war or military conflict, omit the national or ethnic qualifier.

LC practice: Assign the subject headings for the war or event. If location is limited, subdivide geographically to bring out the location of the events in the narrative. If necessary, bring out the nationality or ethnic background of the narrator(s) through a separate class of persons heading designating nationality, ethnicity, etc., if not covered by the geographic subdivision. If using that separate class of persons heading, subdivide geographically to bring out the location of the events in the personal narrative, unless it would be redundant. If the contents of the personal narrative also include descriptions and explanations of past events related to that class of persons, also use the subdivisions ***--History*** as instructed in H 1647. Optionally, also assign LCDGT to express the nationality or ethnicity of the creators. Assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Personal narratives*** and/or a more specific term, e.g. ***Diaries***.

Examples:

651 #0 $a United States $x History $y Revolution, 1775-1783 $v Personal narratives.

651 #0 $a United States $x History $y Revolution, 1775-1983 $v Personal narratives, British.

[but not 651 #0 $a United States $x History $y Revolution, 1995-1783 $v Personal narratives, American.]

LC practice:

386 ## $a Americans $2 lcdgt

386 ## $a Britons $2 lcdgt

651 #0 $a United States $x History $y Revolution, 1775-1783.

650 #0 $a British $z United States $x History $y 18th century.

650 #0 $a Americans $x History $y 18th century.

655 #7 $a Personal narratives. $2 lcgft

650 #0 $a COVID-19 Pandemic, 2020-2023 $z United States $v Personal narratives.

650 #0 $a Government physicians $z United States $v Biography.

LC practice:

386 ## $a Americans $2 lcdgt

650 #0 $a COVID-19 Pandemic, 2020-2023 $z United States.

650 #0 $a Government physicians $z United States.

655 #7 $a Personal narratives. $2 lcgft

F. Assignment of subject headings

F.1. Name heading for the person

For individual personal narratives, assign the name of the author of the work as a subject heading.

F.2. [Class of persons]--Biography

If an individual personal narrative contains at least 50% autobiographical information, treat it as a biography following the provisions of H 1330. If the work is an eyewitness report containing less than 50% autobiographical details, do not treat it as a biography.

F.3. Other subject headings

Assign other subject headings as appropriate to the work being cataloged.

G. Order of headings

G.1. Narratives that include personal information about the author

If an individual personal narrative contains a significant amount of personal information regarding the author, assign the name of the author as the first subject heading.

G.2. Narratives with little personal information about the author

If the narrative is essentially an eyewitness account of what happened with little personal information about the author, assign the name of the war or event as the first subject heading; assign the name of the author as an additional subject heading.

H. Extended examples

Title: Few eggs and no oranges.

[diary about Londoners written by one person during World War II]

600 10 $a Hodgson, Vere $v Diaries.

650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945 $v Personal narratives, British.

651 #0 $a London (England) $x Social life and customs $y 20th century.

651 #0 $a Birmingham (England) $x Social life and customs $y 20th century.

LC practice:

600 10 $a Hodgson, Vere.

650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945 $z England $z London.

651 #0 $a London (England) $x Social life and customs $y 20th century.

651 #0 $a Birmingham (England) $x Social life and customs $y 20th century.

655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Personal narratives. $2 lcgft

Title: A rumor of war.

600 10 $a Caputo, Philip. [name of author]

650 #0 $a Vietnam War, 1961-1975 $v Personal narratives, American.

650 #0 $a Soldiers $z United States $v Biography.

610 10 $a United States. $b Marine Corps $v Biography.

LC practice:

386 ## $a Americans $2 lcdgt

386 ## $a Military personnel $2 lcdgt

600 10 $a Caputo, Philip. [name of author]

650 #0 $a Vietnam War, 1961-1975.

650 #0 $a Americans $z Vietnam.

650 #0 $a Soldiers $z United States.

610 10 $a United States. $b Marine Corps.

655 #7 $a Personal narratives. $2 lcgft

Title: Adventure in diplomacy : our French dilemma.

650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945 $z Africa, North.

650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945 $x Diplomatic history.

600 10 $a Pendar, Kenneth, 1906-1972. [name of author]

650 #0 $a World War, 1939 1945 $v Personal narratives, American.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945 $z Africa, North.

650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945 $x Diplomatic history.

600 10 $a Pendar, Kenneth, 1906-1972. [name of author]

650 #0 $a Americans $z Africa, North $x History $y 20th century.

655 #7 $a Personal narratives. $2 lcgft

Title: The year of the buzz bomb; a journal of London, 1944.

651 #0 $a London (England) $x History $y Bombardment, 1944 $v Personal narratives, American.

600 10 $a Baker, Richard Brown $v Diaries. [name of author]

650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945 $z England $z London.

650 #0 $a Guided missiles $x History.

LC practice:

386 ## $a Americans $2 lcdgt

651 #0 $a London (England) $x History $y Bombardment, 1944.

650 #0 $a Americans $z England $z London.

600 10 $a Baker, Richard Brown. [name of author]

650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945 $z England $z London.

650 #0 $a Guided missiles $x History.

655 #7 $a Personal narratives. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Diaries. $2 lcgft

Revision history

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